





ART UNINHIBITED (clockwise from left) snippets from the 2019 edition—singer Rekha Bhardwaj during a performance; Mayuri Upadhya's *Once Upon a Time*, Lina Vincent and Akshay Mahajan's *Goa Familia*, and an art installation

region-specific projects, workshops for people with specific needs and a dedicated segment with children's programmes," says Sunil Kant Munjal, founder-patron of the Serendipity Arts Foundation.

The curators include over a dozen top artists from different art forms, including Sandeep Kumar Sangaru and Anjana Somany for craft, Quasar Thakore Padamsee for theatre and Geeta Chandran and Mayuri Upadhya for classical, experimental and contemporary dance performances and workshops. Chef Thomas Zacharias and The Locavore team will take visitors through a gastronomical journey that ties people and cultures.

"While it is difficult to handpick a few names from our dynamic programming, there are some interesting culinary workshops that will explore food and sustainable ways of eating. There is also a focus on cultivating sustainability with permaculture gardening this time around," says Munjal.

The lineup of events at the sixth edition promises to pique the interest of visitors of all age groups. One of the highlights is Pandit Zakir Hussain's act on the opening day of the festival. Another unique presentation is the marriage between the ancient art forms of Kaavad and Mohiniyattam.

The River Raag that was conceptualised and curated by musician Shubha Mudgal in the early editions of the festival continues to be a hot favourite. The unique sunset cruise that departs from Santa Monica Jetty features classical performances curated by award-winning musicians Bickram Ghosh and Ricky Kej.

"There will also be engaging conversations featuring a diverse array of panellists, many of whom are subject matter experts. The beauty of our interdisciplinary festival is that it is a potpourri; there's something for everyone," says Munjal.

In a world where gadgets occupy a big chunk of our time, the festival seeks to encourage friends and families to enjoy the creative influx of craft, culinary and performing arts. While Goa has been the centre of action for the Serendipity Arts Festival ever since its inception, there are plans to offer specific aspects of the festival in other cities. "Through our #BeyondSerendipity campaign this year, we travelled to cities like Puducherry, Kolkata and New Delhi. We plan to make this initiative an integral part of our yearly calendar and subsequently add new cities with every chapter," says Munjal. ■

Geetika Sachdev

used to articulate the gist of the Mahindra Kabira Festival when it all started. Staying true to this vision...the two-day programme will offer a wonderful holistic experience," says Jay Shah, vice-president, Head-Cultural Outreach at Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, adding, "This year, the audience is in store for a veritable feast for their senses."

The festival schedule is split into three sessions—morning, afternoon and evening—over two days. It begins with an opening reception performance on December 16 by Hindustani classical vocalist Sveta Kilpady, who will present some of Kabir's dohas in an amalgamation of compositions. "Kabir's life was an ideal example of communal solidarity, spreading the message of love, devotion, and harmony in tumultuous times," says Kilpady. She has been greatly influenced by Kabir's dohas, and says, "I first heard about Kabir in school, and ever since have been intrigued by his teachings. His dohas are simple two-liners with profound teachings and a wealth of learning, favouring a humane approach for the enlightenment of the soul."

Other performers on the first morning session include the award-winning Raagi Sandeep Singh and his *taus*, and classical vocalist Bhuvanesh Komkali, whose performance will be a tribute to the centenary year of his late grandfather, Pandit Kumar Gandharva.

The second morning's session includes performances by Purnesh Bhagwat, a classical vocalist, followed by the duo Kartikeya and Makrand who will take the audience at Guleria Ghat on a mystical journey through flute and percussion.

The festival's afternoon sessions will see discourses through poetry and music by eminent scholars like Purushottam Agrawal and Dr Linda Hess, and an interpretation of Banaras on canvas by artist Paresh Maity.

The evening sessions over the two days will showcase some of the country's most celebrated names: Ashwini Bhide-Deshpande, Padma Shri Ustad Anwar Khan Manganiar, and the Vasu Dixit Collective. The festival will conclude with a performance by legendary folk-fusion band Indian Ocean. For more information, see mahindrakabira.com. ■

Sharmistha Chaudhuri